

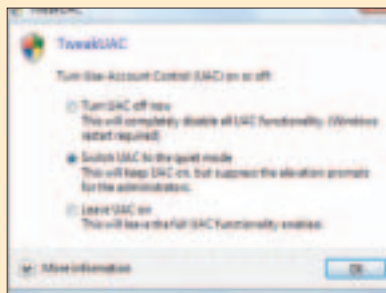
Interface issues

There's no doubt that Windows Vista looks a lot better than XP. The excellent new wallpaper images, high-resolution icons, transparent windows and clever graphical features all help to create an attractive working environment. And yet Windows Vista is still lagging behind the competition in several important areas.

Take the Desktop, for instance. Linux users can have several virtual desktops, perhaps with a full-screen browser running in one, word processor in another, and smaller applications in a third, then switch between them at a click. Windows Vista users must manage all their applications in a single desktop, which is limiting by comparison. Still, there are utilities that can be of use. Dexpot (www.dexpot.de) and Virtuawin (<http://virtuawin.sourceforge.net>)

Taming User Account Control

Some people see User Account Control (UAC) as a big Windows Vista flaw. They're annoyed by all those prompts asking for permission to do just about anything, so they turn it off at the earliest opportunity. But this is a mistake. Not only does UAC help make your PC safer, it's also the power



Adjust settings with TweakUAC

behind Internet Explorer's Protected Mode (a handy security bonus in itself) and several other features. Disable UAC and you'll lose them all. Your system may even develop mysterious new instabilities as a result.

The best solution is to leave UAC turned on. But if you're tired of the prompts, launch Regedit and go to `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Policies\System`. Double-click `ConsentPromptBehaviorAdmin` in the right-hand pane, set its value to 0 (use 2 later to restore the default setting), and click OK. You won't see any more alerts, but UAC will continue to run in the background, which means you'll still benefit from Internet Explorer Protected Mode and its other useful features.

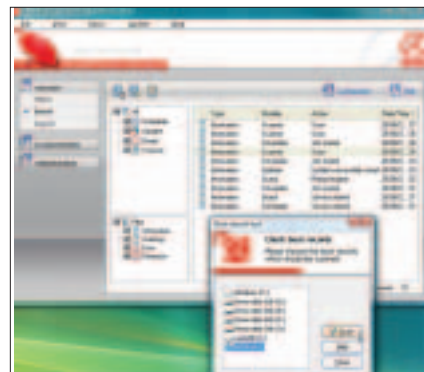
let you arrange your apps across anything up to 20 desktops, and Microsoft has even released a similar tool of its own in the shape of its Desktops utility (<http://technet.microsoft.com/en-us/sysinternals/cc817881.aspx>). Maybe it will find its way into a future version of Windows.

Flip 3D — Vista's three-dimensional alternative to switching through open apps using the Alt and Tab shortcut — looks good, but application windows overlay each other, which can make it hard to pick out the program you need. Switcher (<http://insentient.net>) tiles the windows for better visibility, and throws in searching, shortcuts and other productivity-boosting tweaks.

Not everyone is keen on the new-style Start menu, and it's easy to use the XP version instead (right-click the Start button, select Properties, choose Classic start menu). This doesn't have a search box, but you can get that by installing Launchy (www.launchy.net). Or, if you prefer the keyboard to the mouse, try Start++ (<http://brandontools.com/content/StartPlusPlus.aspx>). It lets you create easy keyboard shortcuts to quickly perform just about any task.

Security matters

Windows Vista's security has come a long way since Windows XP, but still includes a number of problems that you'll want to rectify as soon as possible. The new firewall, for instance, is packed with features, yet somehow still makes it difficult to trap outgoing connections. Replace it with the excellent free Comodo firewall (www.personalfirewall.comodo.com).



And while it's good to see that Windows now includes an anti-spyware tool in Windows Defender, you

You can't rely on Windows Defender to protect you from all malware, so get some help from a dedicated anti-virus tool. Thankfully utilities like Avira Antivir are completely free